

**T**he most indelible sporting visual etched in my mind is of Leander Paes, standing on the Olympic victory podium in 1996 with a bronze medal around his neck and drops of tears trickling down his face. Then I had remarked to a friend, "Why is he crying? I did not know he was so soft." Two years later, as I stood on the podium at the 1998 Bangkok Asian Games with my doubles partner Ashok Shandilya, after winning the gold medal for Billiards, as India's national anthem was played and the *tiranga* slowly hoisted up, without warning I broke down uncontrollably too. There is something deeply moving

about winning a medal for your country at either the Asian Games or the Olympics. The achievement instills great pride and invokes an emotional response like none other into both the athlete and his or her countrymen.

Our masses though, are addicted to cricket, which has successfully transformed itself from a mere sport into a multi-million dollar entertainment industry. Our cricket victories, however, are few. A World Cup win in 1983 and then more recently a Twenty20 World Cup triumph. Nothing much to celebrate, considering that not more than a dozen countries participate in the sport which occupies our intense focus.

Yet, "success breeds success and money gets more money". The marketing of cricket has emphatically proved this but despite the overwhelming popularity of the sport and its stars, it remains a non-Olympic sport and has no chance in the foreseeable future of inclusion at the most romanticised of sporting platforms.

So every four years for the last 60 years, we have waited with bated breath for some miracle which will fuel our collective sporting pride. We have had some success in hockey—eight Olympic golds—but since 1980 the decline in our national sport has left us looking elsewhere and has been the topic of many heated debates.

India's sporting history, other than this period of excellence in hockey, is depressing, uncomfortable and disheartening. Milkha Singh missed a bronze medal by one-tenth of a second in the 400 meters despite a time faster than the world record in the 1960 Rome Olympics and in 1984 P.T. Usha missed the bronze by one-hundredth of a second in the 400 meters hurdles at Los Angeles. They had archaic training methods nowhere

close to standards then prevailing in the world. Theirs were stories of grit, commitment, courage and hope and they perfected their craft despite the system and not because of it.

There are countless documented stories of lack of support, neglect and inefficiencies, which were responsible for athletes failing to achieve their full potential. In individual disciplines, we failed to bring back a single medal until 1996 when Paes broke the drought with a bronze winning effort at the Atlanta Games. At the 2000 Sydney Olympics, Karnam Malleswari brought glory for herself and India by clinching a bronze medal in weightlifting. I was present at a dinner hosted for the Indian Olympic contingent in Sydney. Malleswari had already won the bronze, yet I viewed with dismay the sheer hopelessness in the eyes and body language of our athletes.

My submission is that as a system we crush and stamp out the self-worth and dignity of our athletes. Athletes are required to be submissive, obsequious, and subservient to the needs and demands of people who govern them. The consequences of not toeing the line is usually career-threatening for the athlete. By its very definition, excellence in sport is about pride of performance. It's about inculcating self-discipline and self-worth through success in the match arena, which should result in honour and financial rewards which in turn again feed and reinforce the dignity and self-worth of the athlete. But when the petty egos of small-minded officials consistently and ferociously demand athletes to be subservient and obsequious, they may be

The Beijing Olympics marked India's most successful Games ever, as the contingent came back with a gold and two bronzes.

**Rs 3,073 crore**

is the amount the 2009 Budget has earmarked for sports.

It is still nowhere close to what China was ready to spend for the Beijing Olympics. Approximately \$5.56 million was spent for every medal won.

**THE BENEFITS OF TREATISE AND POLITICAL SUCCESS ARE EXPERIENCED BY FUTURE GENERATIONS WHILE SPORTING GLORIES PROVIDE INSTANT GRATIFICATION.**